

CHAPTER 5

Executive Skills

Cogito ergo sum. [I think, therefore I am.]
—RENÉ DESCARTES (1596–1650)

For school-based evaluators, who are routinely confronted with a variety of interfering behaviors, the value of an FBA model increases with knowledge of specific variables that are known to impact behavior. This chapter introduces you to a key set of *executive skills* that are an essential component of all human behavior.

EXECUTIVE SKILLS: A BRIEF INTRODUCTION

Executive skills are a set of high-level cognitive functions possessed by human beings that allow us to accomplish goals and meet challenges across our entire lifespan. Beginning in early infancy, throughout development and into adulthood, these skills play a central role in our capacity for behavioral regulation. They play an essential role in helping us decide which tasks and activities we will attend to and which ones we will decide to do (Hart & Jacobs, 1993). These skills underlie our capacity to organize our behavior over time, override immediate demands and desires in favor of longer-term goals, and persist in task completion. Executive skills enable us to monitor and evaluate our thoughts in order to work more effectively and efficiently and manage our emotions under stressful conditions. Simply stated, these skills are essential for the regulation of our behavior.

The National Scientific Council on the Developing Child at Harvard University (2011) has likened these skills to an air traffic control center in a child's brain. Researchers there note that human beings are born with the neurological potential to develop these skills. However, whether and how they're developed depends on the experiences we have through childhood, adolescence, and into young adulthood. The blueprint for these skills exists in the biology of the brain at birth, but the environment in which we live and the experiences we have throughout development continuously impact brain circuitry and shape the expression

of these skills and behavior. In terms of behavioral intervention, the essential fact to keep in mind is that these skills can be strengthened through practice and experience. The consideration of executive skills when conducting an FBA leads to (1) an operational description of certain personal characteristics (traits) that contribute to interfering behaviors and (2) an understanding of specific skills that may need to be taught to reduce interfering behaviors.

The executive skills that are most likely to have an impact on interfering behavior are presented in Table 5.1, along with definitions, examples of how students demonstrate the skills, and examples of typical referral concerns and/or personal characteristics that are indicative of executive skill deficits. As indicated in the table, any of the executive skills listed may contribute to interfering behavior if the skill represents a significant weakness for the student. When executive skills are hypothesized to be a contributor to interfering behavior, additional assessment may be warranted during the FBA process. At the end of this chapter, we have provided copies of the Executive Skills Questionnaire (parent/teacher and student versions; Forms 5.1 and 5.2), along with the Executive Skills Problem Check-

TABLE 5.1. Executive Skill Definitions and Examples

What is the problem?	Corresponding executive skill and definition	When the executive skill is a strength	When the executive skill is a weakness
Impulsive, impatient	<i>Response inhibition:</i> The capacity to think before acting. The ability to resist the urge to act allows time to evaluate situations and the outcomes of actions.	A young student can wait appropriately for a short period (e.g., responding in a group, standing in line). An older student can accept a teacher's correction without an argument.	A student interrupts, shouts out, grabs objects, insists on talking or being first, and engages in interfering behavior (e.g., arguing, hitting, bolting) when faced with challenges.
Forgets easily, can't hold and mentally manipulate information, doesn't learn from mistakes	<i>Working memory:</i> The ability to hold information in memory while performing complex tasks. It incorporates the ability to draw on past learning or experience to apply to the situation at hand or to project into the future.	A young student can hold in mind and follow short, one- or two-step directions (e.g., "get a red crayon," "circle the numbers"). An older student can remember the expectations set by multiple teachers and uses an assignment book.	A young student needs repeated, step-by-step teacher directions. An older student forgets to write down assignments.
Low frustration tolerance, "short fuse," easily upset	<i>Emotional control:</i> The ability to manage emotions to achieve goals, complete tasks, or control and direct behavior.	A young student can manage frustration and/or recover from a disappointment in a short time with minimal soothing. An older student can manage the stress of a competition or test and still perform.	A student appears angry ("blows up" easily) or anxious. A young student fixates on disappointment and cries excessively. An older student's anxiety causes physical distress and adversely impacts performance.

(continued)

TABLE 5.1. (continued)

What is the problem?	Corresponding executive skill and definition	When the executive skill is a strength	When the executive skill is a weakness
Distractible, unable to focus unless task is interesting	<i>Sustained attention:</i> The capacity to keep paying attention to a situation or task in spite of distractibility, fatigue, or boredom.	A young student completes a 5-minute classroom chore with only occasional redirection. An older student can pay attention to homework, with short breaks, for 1–2 hours.	A student is highly distractible, requires repeated return-to-task prompts, takes frequent breaks, takes 2–3 hours to complete a 1-hour task, or doesn't finish tasks.
Procrastinates, dawdles	<i>Task initiation:</i> The ability to begin projects without undue procrastination, in an efficient or timely fashion.	A young student is able to listen to directions and begin a task promptly. An older student does not wait until the last minute to begin a project.	A young student requires repeated prompts and direct help to start a task. An older student procrastinates until the last minute to begin a project.
Can't develop a strategy or set a direction to move in	<i>Planning/prioritization:</i> The ability to create a roadmap to reach a goal or to complete a task. It also involves being able to make decisions about what is important/not important to focus on.	A young student can gather materials to complete a task with few directions. An older student can formulate a plan to complete a research paper.	A young student needs explicit, step-by-step guidance to get materials needed to complete a task. An older student needs adult help to create a plan and prioritize steps for assignments.
Messy, loses things, disorderly in thinking and acting	<i>Organization:</i> The ability to create and maintain systems to keep track of information or materials.	A young student can put toys in a designated place with a reminder. An older student can organize and locate class materials from a locker.	A young student has to be guided through each step of cleanup. An older student routinely loses belongings.
Inefficient, slow, often late, lacks time awareness or sense of urgency with deadlines	<i>Time management:</i> The capacity to estimate how much time one has, how to allocate it, and how to stay within time limits and deadlines. It also involves a sense that time is important.	A young student can complete a short job within a reasonable time set by an adult. An older student can establish a schedule to meet task deadlines.	Without ongoing help, the student cannot finish tasks on time and often submits assignments late.
Gives up easily when effort is involved	<i>Goal-directed persistence:</i> The capacity to have a goal, follow through to the completion of the goal, and not be distracted by competing interests.	A young student can complete a task to get to recess with minimal redirection. An older student can earn the grades needed to maintain sports eligibility.	A young student needs one-on-one help to finish a task. An older student is unable to meet stated grade goals.

list (elementary and middle/high school versions for teachers and parents; Forms 5.3–5.5) developed by Dawson and Guare (2018). The questionnaires and checklists can be completed by school staff, parents, and/or students themselves to provide an informal assessment of executive skill strengths, weaknesses, and associated behaviors.

EXECUTIVE SKILLS INTERVENTION

In our executive skills model and in our clinical work, we use three intervention strategies to address executive skill weaknesses: environmental modifications, skill instruction, and motivational incentives. Environmental modifications involve changing those “triggering” aspects of the social or instructional environment. Skill instruction is designed to help students develop positive acceptable behaviors as substitutes for interfering behaviors, and motivational incentives are used to strengthen (reinforce) these alternative behaviors. A comprehensive FBA helps identify the triggers for interfering behavior, corresponding executive skills to be taught, and effective ways to reinforce the skills. In the following section, we present two case examples of interventions addressing executive skills for students with weaknesses in response inhibition and flexibility, respectively.

Intervention Example 1: Response Inhibition

Description of Skill

The capacity to think before you act; the capacity to delay or inhibit responding based on the ability to evaluate multiple factors.

Characteristics of Students with a Weakness in Response Inhibition

- Students who have trouble with response inhibition are impulsive, saying or doing things without thinking, which often gets them into trouble with parents, teachers, or peers.
- Any situation that requires delayed gratification is difficult for them.
- Waiting is particularly difficult when students desire the outcomes (e.g., speaking first in a situation, being at the front of the line, or getting a preferred object or outcome).
- These students want to be “first among equals.”

Environmental Modifications

Which situational modifications will best help these students delay or inhibit responding?

1. *Increase external controls.* In other words, limit or restrict access to settings or situations in which the student can get in trouble. For example, a student who becomes overstimulated during recess or physical education classes and has trouble following rules may need limits or restrictions on participating in certain activities until alternative skills can be taught and reinforced. Similarly, students who have trouble keeping

their hands to themselves during circle time may benefit from sitting next to the teacher, a paraprofessional, or a peer who can act as a barrier and use nonverbal prompts (e.g., a hand on the arm, a picture) to help them.

2. *Increase supervision.* When teachers or parents say, “I can’t let him/her out of my sight,” this suggests they have modified the environment by making sure there is an adult present at all times to reduce the likelihood that the student will do something impulsive or dangerous. Students with impulse control problems, particularly when they are young, often require more adult supervision in school settings. This is why the adult-to-student ratio is greater in preschools than in middle school. This is also why schools sometimes assign individual aides to students. The physical presence of an adult in proximity to the student with impulse control problems acts as a prompt or a surrogate executive skill to help the student exercise control.
3. *Establish specific impulse control rules.* This may include posting and reviewing class rules or stopping students before they encounter difficult situations to remind them to exhibit self-control—for example, the teacher says, “What behavior are we working on?” The student says, “Not hitting or running into people when I get frustrated.”

Teaching and Reinforcing the Skill

The focus of instruction is to teach the student competing skills to replace disinhibited responses (e.g., teaching a student to raise her hand before speaking if she typically blurts things out in class). Instruction and reinforcement follows these steps:

1. Explain to the student the skill being worked on and your understanding of the purpose of the student’s disinhibited behavior—for example, “I think you talk out because you’re looking for recognition from me or your classmates. We’re going to work on raising your hand before you speak.” When selecting the replacement skill (e.g., hand raising), make sure the skill being taught meets the same need (i.e., peer or teacher recognition) as the disinhibited response.
2. Have the student practice the skill using a contrived situation or a teaching example. Practice the skill sufficiently, until the student is successful most of the time. You may want to make a game of the process. For instance, if hand raising is the skill being taught, then the practice could include keeping score of how many times the student remembers to raise her hand before speaking and reinforcing these with social approval.
3. When the student is ready to practice the skill in the natural environment, prompt the student to use the skill just prior to the situation in which it will be required. For example, ask the student, “Do you remember what we’re working on?” If the student responds accurately, then say, “Great job, show me how you’ll do it.” If the student is unsure how to respond, prompt the correct response and a demonstration of the skill.
4. Immediately and consistently reinforce use of the skill (e.g., in the early stage of training, if hand raising is the target skill, then call on the student right away whenever she raises her hand and praise her for remembering to raise her hand).
5. Ignore the disinhibited response (e.g., don’t respond when she blurts something out).

6. Gradually fade the prompting and reinforcement (e.g., by not calling on her right away every time she raises her hand). This may be even more effective if you tell the student that this is what you are going to do—for example, “I’m not going to call on you every time. I won’t forget you’re there, but I’m only going to call on you every fourth or fifth time.”

Case Vignette

Circle time was a constant struggle for Kristin and her teacher, Mrs. Brock. In spite of rules about turn taking and not interrupting, Kristin would blurt out information when someone else was talking instead of raising her hand and waiting to be called on. Mrs. Brock decided that providing some cues and a plan for Kristin could help. She first introduced a “talking stick” to the class and indicated that only the person who had the stick could speak at that moment. She also gave two chips to each student that they could “spend” by asking two questions once the speaker indicated it was time for questions. At this point, the students would raise their hands and the teacher would call on one. Recognizing Kristin’s difficulty waiting, for the first week the teacher called on her first. If Kristin forgot and blurted something out before the speaker was finished, she had to give up one of her chips. This, along with initially sitting next to the teacher, was usually sufficient to help her remember. However, on a few occasions Kristin (and a few other students) “spent” both chips before the speaker was done and needed to leave the circle. Kristin found this system helpful, and after the first week she was able to decide with her teacher how many students she felt she could wait for before asking her questions.

Intervention Example 2: Flexibility

Description of Skill

The ability to revise plans in the face of obstacles, setbacks, new information, or mistakes; it relates to an adaptability to changing conditions or unexpected outcomes.

Characteristics of Students with a Weakness in Flexibility

- Uncertainty or ambiguity (e.g., not knowing a schedule or an answer, unexpectedly losing a game, or unscripted social interactions) produces significant stress.
- If the unexpected happens, it often triggers a fight (aggressive behavior) or flight (avoidance/escape behavior) response.
- Inflexibility often goes hand in hand with reduced emotional control.
- Without an agenda from another person, students construct their own agendas, which favor the outcomes they want.
- Since uncertainty produces stress, the agendas students construct are not seen as a possibility, a “may be,” but rather a certainty, a “will be.”
- If another person (e.g., parent, teacher, or peer) interferes with the agenda, an emotional and behavioral “meltdown” can occur.

Environmental Modifications

Which situational modifications will best help these students cope with uncertainty and increase their flexibility over time?

1. *Reduce the novelty of the situation.* Advance notification, whenever possible, is the goal. Classrooms with consistent schedules and routines are a good fit for these students, and picture or written schedules can be personalized for and reviewed with the student. When presenting schedules, try not to attach precise times to the activities unless necessary (as with sports events and lessons), and use time ranges instead (e.g., reading will start between 9:30 and 9:45 A.M.). Preteach for new tasks and arrange walk-through rehearsals for new activities to reduce novelty.
2. *Prepare for the unexpected.* Unexpected changes occur in school. Talk with the student about the fact that changes or “surprises” can always come up despite plans and schedules, and give examples (e.g., indoor recess on a rainy day, a teacher being absent, or fire alarms). To address this, make a “Surprise!” card for the schedule and explain that when a change is coming, you will show the card, say what the change is, and put it on the schedule. Even when a change comes up that’s a surprise to everyone, you can pull out the card and follow the same process. Spontaneous “teachable moments” are one example of this.
3. *Implement additional advance notification strategies.* When possible, introduce the change well before the event, giving the student time to adjust gradually rather than quickly. Depending on his or her reaction to less pleasant change (e.g., crying, resisting, complaining), talk about appropriate ways to protest (e.g., using a “complaint form”). Reinforce successful responses to change. Keep in mind that reactivity to change decreases with the amount of exposure that the student has to successfully negotiating it. As long as the exposure is gradual and does not initially involve situations that are frustrating or threatening, the student can become more flexible.
4. *Modify the nature of tasks.* Novel and unstructured tasks can be difficult for students with weaknesses in flexibility. Tasks can be modified by (a) decreasing the speed, volume, or complexity of information presented and routinely checking with the student to ensure understanding; (b) adapting open-ended tasks to make them more closed-ended (e.g., substituting expectations to make up sentences with vocabulary words with fill-in-the-blank sentences); and/or (c) providing and reviewing explicit templates or rubrics to follow when completing assignments.
5. *Increase the level of support with tasks.* This can be done by (a) offering frequent verbal reassurance, (b) providing step-by-step assistance in working through difficult problems, (c) using guided mastery and fading assistance as the student’s understanding and success increase, (d) maintaining close contact with the student at transition times, or (e) cuing the student to use self-management strategies (see below).
6. *Identify and prepare for situations that require flexibility.* Open-ended social situations (e.g., recess, lunch, and free time in PE classes) can be troublesome because unscripted social interactions require flexible social communication skills. Having the student pre-

select activities (e.g., the use of particular equipment on the playground or games that capitalize on the student's skills and knowledge of rules) and peers with whom to interact can avoid some of these issues. At the middle and high school levels, similar planning may be needed prior to transitions between classes.

Teaching and Reinforcing the Skill

The focus of instruction is to teach the student competing skills to replace negative reactions to unexpected change. Instruction and reinforcement follow these steps:

1. Explain to the student the skill being worked on and your understanding of the purpose of the student's inflexible behavior. For example, "I think you get upset because you think one thing is going to happen and something different happens, like you are expecting math and instead the teacher says it is reading time." When selecting the replacement skill (e.g., a self-talk strategy), make sure the skill being taught meets the same need (i.e., decreases the distress) as the inflexible response.
2. Use role-play scenarios to practice the skill and then assign the student to practice the skill in actual school situations. Provide prompts and high rates of reinforcement in the early stages of skill teaching, and gradually fade support over time.
3. Teach and reinforce the use of self-talk scripts. Kenworthy and colleagues (2014) begin by teaching students words and phrases to label relevant skills. For example, they introduce the word *flexible* to the student and provide an explanation of the word's meaning. They follow this with a set of phrases that the student can use in relevant situations, such as "I need to be flexible," "Being flexible helps me get some of what I want," "I can be flexible, I've done it before" (Kenworthy et al., 2014, p. 26). They also use the key words *choice/no choice* to help students manage frustrating situations. Associated self-script phrases include: "Is this a choice or no-choice situation?"; "This is a no-choice situation because . . ."; "I don't have any other choice so I must do this. I'll take a deep breath and then do it one step at a time. I've done this before, and I know I can do it again" (Kenworthy et al., 2014, p. 31).
4. Once students are able to recognize inflexibility in themselves, the next step is to teach them self-management strategies for managing their emotions and the situation. Teaching self-management strategies involves modeling, practice, feedback, reinforcement, and generalization to real settings, with cues to prompt the student to use the strategy until the skill is mastered. Strategies to support self-management include:
 - Giving students explicit plans or rules for managing specific situations that arise frequently.
 - Helping students identify "default" strategies they can fall back on (e.g., going to a designated location when frustrated).
 - Teaching students relaxation, thought-stopping, or attention-diversion strategies (e.g., using visual imagery).
 - Teaching students the concept of an "error factor" to reduce absolutist thinking. For instance, some students become very upset in sports situations when an umpire or

referee makes a call that they think is wrong. Preparing students in advance for this by letting them know that those officiating games are “allowed” to make mistakes may reduce unhappiness when perceived bad calls are made.

5. Gradually introduce changes into the day/schedule. Initially, introduce preferred activities (e.g., “Surprise, it’s time to play a game on the computer!”) with warnings and then, as the child adjusts, without warnings. As the student gets used to this, move on to “neutral” and then less preferred activities. Reinforce acceptance of change. “Inoculate” the student by presenting change in small doses.

Case Vignettes

When lining up for recess and lunch, a third-grade boy insisted on being first in line and often pushed his way to the front. We discussed that the class rule was that each student in class took turns being line leader for the day and explained that the teacher decided this based on alphabetical order of names. Thus, this was a no-choice situation in which, according to classroom rules, every student had an opportunity to be line leader. Each day the teacher reviewed with him his position in the line-leader queue. When he lined up as directed, his teacher congratulated him for making a good choice. We also created a token reinforcement system for him so that each day he took his correct position in line he earned a token. When he had five tokens, he could choose a prize from the prize bin in the case manager’s office. When the student pushed his way to the front, he had to sit and wait until the class was leaving and then join the line at the end. Over a period of 2 weeks, the student was able to make consistently good choices.

Jeff, age 10, was a creature of habit. He struggled with transitions and had difficulty in the first few weeks of each new school year until he became familiar with the schedule and his new teachers’ expectations. In fourth grade, he continued to struggle even after 2½ months. His teacher followed a schedule, but since work expectations could vary from day to day, students had to be flexible about the start times for each subject. This was very frustrating to Jeff. Each day when he came to school, he expected that his teacher would do reading and language arts before recess and math right after recess. In addition, he struggled with the open-ended nature of writing but looked forward to math because the subject matter was clearly defined—black and white. When writing spilled over into math time, Jeff got very upset and sometimes refused to finish. To help Jeff with this, his teacher gave him an explicit, step-by-step strategy for writing and worked with him on applying this. She also checked in with him every morning. When the language arts material for the day looked complex and might run into math time, they worked out an altered schedule that would help him “reset” his expectations, and they practiced an “I need to be flexible” script. The teacher also set clear criteria for Jeff’s completion of language arts work and gave him the option of starting some math when it was done. She delivered praise for his effort to use his writing strategies and self-talk scripts. Over time, she worked with Jeff on estimating how much time his work would take, emphasizing that an “estimate” is just that, and continued to encourage him to use his “I need to be flexible” script to cope with changes in work schedules.

SUMMARY

In the context of FBA, our goal is to understand the individual characteristics each student brings to the table and the manner in which these individual variables interact with other contextual variables to increase the probability of interfering behavior. Executive skills are essential for students to navigate the school environment successfully. When executive skills are weak, students are more likely to experience typical school situations as challenging (or aversive) and to engage in behaviors that do not match teacher expectations. Identification of executive skill deficits during the FBA process therefore facilitates a comprehensive conceptualization of why students engage in interfering behaviors and informs the development of behavior intervention plans that emphasize skill acquisition, rather than focusing exclusively on the reduction of interfering behavior.

Additional Resources

In over 30 years of clinical practice, Drs. Peg Dawson and Richard Guare have worked with thousands of children who struggle at home and in school. At the center of these struggles are weak executive skills. To learn more about assessment and intervention for executive skills, check out these recent books:

Dawson, P., & Guare, R. (2016). *The smart but scattered guide to success: How to use your brain's executive skills to keep up, stay calm, and get organized at work and at home*. New York: Guilford Press.

Dawson, P., & Guare, R. (2018). *Executive skills in children and adolescents: A practical guide to assessment and intervention* (3rd ed.). New York: Guilford Press.

Guare, R., Guare, C., & Dawson, P. (2019). *Smart but scattered—and stalled: 10 steps to help young adults use their executive skills to set goals, make a plan, and successfully leave the nest*. New York: Guilford Press.

Also take the time to explore their website (www.smartbutscatteredkids.com) to learn more about the resources available for improving executive skills in children and adolescents both at home and at school.

FORM 5.1

Executive Skills Questionnaire for Parents/Teachers

Big problem	1
Moderate problem	2
Mild problem	3
Slight problem	4
No problem	5

Item	Score
1. Acts on impulse	_____
2. Gets in trouble for talking too much in class	_____
3. Says things without thinking	_____
TOTAL SCORE:	_____
4. Says, "I'll do it later" and then forgets about it	_____
5. Forgets homework assignments or forgets to bring home needed materials	_____
6. Loses or misplaces belongings such as coats, mittens, sports equipment, etc.	_____
TOTAL SCORE:	_____
7. Gets annoyed when homework is too hard or confusing or takes too long to finish	_____
8. Has a short fuse; easily frustrated	_____
9. Easily upset when things don't go as planned	_____
TOTAL SCORE:	_____
10. Difficulty paying attention; easily distracted	_____
11. Runs out of steam before finishing homework or other tasks	_____
12. Problems sticking with schoolwork or chores until they are done	_____
TOTAL SCORE:	_____
13. Puts off homework or chores until the last minute	_____
14. Difficulty setting aside fun activities in order to start homework	_____
15. Needs many reminders to start chores	_____
TOTAL SCORE:	_____
16. Trouble planning for big assignments (knowing what to do first, second, etc.)	_____
17. Difficulty setting priorities when has a lot of things to do	_____
18. Becomes overwhelmed by long-term projects or big assignments	_____
TOTAL SCORE:	_____

(continued)

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Executive Skills Questionnaire for Parents/Teachers (page 2 of 2)

Item	Score
19. Backpack and notebooks are disorganized	_____
20. Desk or workspace at home or school is a mess	_____
21. Trouble keeping bedroom or locker tidy	_____
TOTAL SCORE:	_____
22. Has a hard time estimating how long it takes to do something (such as homework)	_____
23. Often doesn't finish homework at night; rushes to get it done in school before class	_____
24. Slow getting ready for things (e.g., appointments, school, changing classes)	_____
TOTAL SCORE:	_____
25. If the first solution to a problem doesn't work, has trouble thinking of a different one	_____
26. Resists changes in plans or routines	_____
27. Has problems with open-ended homework assignments (e.g., doesn't know what to write about when given a creative writing assignment)	_____
TOTAL SCORE:	_____

High School Students Only

28. Lacks effective study strategies	_____
29. Doesn't check work for mistakes even when the stakes are high	_____
30. Doesn't evaluate performance and change tactics in order to increase success	_____
TOTAL SCORE:	_____
31. Can't seem to save up money for a desired object; problems delaying gratification	_____
32. Doesn't see the value in earning good grades to achieve a long-term goal	_____
33. Seems to live in the present	_____
TOTAL SCORE:	_____

KEY			
Items	Executive Skill	Items	Executive Skill
1–3	Response inhibition	4–6	Working memory
7–9	Emotional control	10–12	Sustained attention
13–15	Task initiation	16–18	Planning/prioritization
19–21	Organization	22–24	Time management
25–27	Flexibility	28–30	Metacognition
31–33	Goal-directed persistence		

Child's Executive Skills Strengths

Child's Executive Skills Weaknesses

Executive Skills Questionnaire for Students

Directions: Read each item and decide how often it's a problem for you. Then add up the three scores in each set and write that number on the **Total score** line. Use the **Key** on page 69 to determine your executive skills strengths (two to three highest scores) and weaknesses (two to three lowest scores).

1. I act on impulse.

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

2. I get in trouble for talking too much in class.

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

3. I say things without thinking.

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

Total score, items 1–3: _____

4. I say “I’ll do it later” and then forget about it.

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

5. I forget homework assignments or forget to bring home needed materials.

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

6. I lose or misplace belongings such as coats, notebooks, sports equipment, etc.

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

Total score, items 4–6: _____

7. I get annoyed when homework is too hard or confusing or takes too long to finish.

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

8. I have a short fuse, am easily frustrated.

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

9. I get upset easily when things don’t go as planned.

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

Total score, items 7–9: _____

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Executive Skills Questionnaire for Students (page 2 of 4)

10. **I have difficulty paying attention, am easily distracted.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

11. **I run out of steam before finishing my homework.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

12. **I have problems sticking with chores until they are done.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

Total score, items 10–12: _____

13. **I put off homework or chores until the last minute.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

14. **It's hard for me to put aside fun activities to start homework.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

15. **I need many reminders to start chores.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

Total score, items 13–15: _____

16. **I have trouble planning for big assignments (knowing what to do first, second, etc.).**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

17. **It's hard for me to set priorities when I have a lot of things to do.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

18. **I become overwhelmed by long-term projects or big assignments.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

Total score, items 16–18: _____

(continued)

Executive Skills Questionnaire for Students (page 3 of 4)

19. **My backpack and notebooks are disorganized.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

20. **My desk or workspace at home is a mess.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

21. **I have trouble keeping my room tidy.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

Total score, items 19–21: _____

22. **I have a hard time estimating how long it takes to do something (such as homework).**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

23. **I often don't finish homework at night and rush to get it done in school before class.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

24. **I'm slow getting ready for things (e.g., school or appointments).**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

Total score, items 22–24: _____

25. **If the first solution to a problem doesn't work, I have trouble thinking of a different one.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

26. **It's hard for me to deal with changes in plans or routines.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

27. **I have problems with open-ended homework assignments (e.g., knowing what to write about for a creative writing assignment or coming up with topics for a long-term project).**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

Total score, items 25–27: _____

(continued)

Executive Skills Questionnaire for Students (page 4 of 4)

28. **I don't have effective study strategies.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

29. **I don't check my work for mistakes even when the stakes are high.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

30. **I don't evaluate my performance and change tactics to increase my success.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

Total score, items 28–30: _____

31. **I can't seem to save up money for something I want.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

32. **I don't see the value in earning good grades to achieve a long-term goal.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

33. **If something fun comes up when I should be studying, it's hard for me to make myself study.**

Most of the time	Frequently	Sometimes	Very rarely	Never
1	2	3	4	5

Total score, items 31–33: _____

KEY

<u>Items</u>	<u>Executive Skill</u>	<u>Items</u>	<u>Executive Skill</u>
1–3	Response inhibition	4–6	Working memory
7–9	Emotional control	10–12	Sustained attention
13–15	Task initiation	16–18	Planning/prioritization
19–21	Organization	22–24	Time management
25–27	Flexibility	28–30	Metacognition
31–33	Goal-directed persistence		

Your Executive Skills Strengths

Your Executive Skills Weaknesses

Executive Skills Problem Checklist, Elementary Version—Teacher

Directions:

1. Read each item and decide whether the student in question exhibits this problem *to a significantly greater degree* than other children in the same grade level.
2. Look over all the items you checked and choose THREE that you think cause the greatest problems. Place a star (★) next to those.

Response Inhibition

- _____ Blurts out inappropriate comments
- _____ In a teacher-directed activity, does not wait until the person talking finishes and he/she is acknowledged by the teacher before offering a response
- _____ Can't wait turn in games
- _____ Does not use acceptable language to handle conflict situations
- _____ Does not remain at his/her seat or assigned area during seatwork time and classroom lessons
- _____ Does not complete seatwork or assignments accurately

Working Memory

- _____ Doesn't write down all homework in assignment books or other designated location
- _____ Doesn't bring all necessary materials to and from school every day (e.g., homework, notebooks/binders, permission slips, gym clothes, lunch money, coats/hats/mittens, etc.)
- _____ Doesn't hand in assignments on the dates they are due
- _____ Doesn't remember where to find all necessary materials to get through the school day and to complete homework
- _____ Doesn't follow all instructions accurately for multistep tasks by using checklists or rubrics if necessary

Emotional Control

- _____ Leaves class or becomes visibly upset rather than asking for help when he/she doesn't understand an assignment
- _____ Engages in verbal or physical aggression or unsafe behavior when playing with other students at recess
- _____ Doesn't use coping strategies to recover when he/she begins to get upset (or angry, frustrated, anxious)
- _____ Anxiety interferes with test performance
- _____ Anxiety interferes with classroom presentations
- _____ Becomes very upset or responds with verbal or physical aggression when teased or taunted by other students

(continued)

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Executive Skills Problem Checklist, Elementary Version—Teacher (page 2 of 2)

Flexibility

- _____ Becomes very upset when confronted with the unexpected (e.g., changes in plans or routines, disappointment, being told “no”)
- _____ Has difficulty managing transitions between activities or settings
- _____ Is unable to come up with one or more alternative plans or solutions when the first strategy doesn’t work (no Plan B)
- _____ Is unable to complete open-ended tasks successfully according to the rubric assigned

Sustained Attention

- _____ Doesn’t complete classwork and homework within the time allotted or within suggested time frames
- _____ Loses focus on class lessons (as demonstrated by not being able to answer questions related to the content of the lesson or by not understanding assignments associated with the lesson)

Task Initiation

- _____ Has difficulty starting class assignments within 3 minutes of the prompt to begin working
- _____ Stretches out breaks and fails to return to work promptly with longer or less preferred work tasks

Planning/Prioritization

- _____ Has difficulty setting priorities (in what order to do tasks, how much time to spend on any given task)
- _____ Doesn’t know what to focus on when studying for tests
- _____ Writing does not follow a logical sequence; paragraphs don’t contain main ideas and supporting details

Organization

- _____ Does not place materials in a specified place in notebooks, backpacks, desks, and study areas
- _____ Does not follow an organizational system with consistency (e.g., throwing out unnecessary papers, not placing homework assignments in assigned spot, organizing papers for each subject separately)
- _____ Does not have a tidy study area

Time Management

- _____ Does not complete assignments within the time allotted or by the due date
- _____ Can’t adjust work speed to fit the time available

Goal-Directed Persistence

- _____ Does not persist with effortful tasks
- _____ Gives up in the face of an obstacle
- _____ Has a “good-enough” mentality that gets in the way of producing quality work

Metacognition

- _____ Cannot judge the quality of his/her own work
- _____ Does not know how to improve work
- _____ Has difficulty making inferences, drawing conclusions, grasping the main idea, reading between the lines
- _____ Fails to check work/proofread/use spell-check

Executive Skills Problem Checklist, Middle/High School Version

Directions:

1. Check (✓) problem areas that significantly interfere with effective studying.
2. Look over all the items you checked and choose THREE that you think cause the greatest problems. Place a star (★) next to those.

Response Inhibition

- _____ Rushing through work just to get it done
- _____ Not having the patience to produce quality work
- _____ Giving up on a homework assignment when I encounter an obstacle
- _____ Having trouble doing homework when there are more fun things to do

Working Memory

- _____ Writing assignment instructions without enough detail to understand later
- _____ Forgetting to take home necessary materials or take materials to class
- _____ Forgetting to hand in homework
- _____ Forgetting long-term projects or upcoming tests
- _____ Not paying attention to classroom instructions/task directions
- _____ Trouble remembering multiple directions or multiple problem steps
- _____ Losing materials
- _____ Forgetting to complete assignments
- _____ Forgetting to check agenda/assignment book
- _____ Not recording when an assignment is due

Emotional Control

- _____ Getting really irritated when a homework assignment is hard or confusing
- _____ Finding it hard to get started on assignments because of perfectionism or fear of failure
- _____ Freezing when taking tests and doing poorly despite studying long and hard
- _____ Not seeing the point of an assignment and finding it hard to motivate myself to do it

Task Initiation

Procrastinating/avoiding tasks due to:

- _____ not knowing how to get started
- _____ believing the task will “take forever”

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Executive Skills Problem Checklist, Middle/High School Version (page 2 of 4)

- ___ believing my performance won't meet expectations
- ___ seeing the task as tedious, boring, or irrelevant
- ___ Finding other things to do rather than starting homework
- ___ Difficulty getting back to work after breaks

Sustained Attention

- ___ Taking frequent breaks when working
- ___ Taking breaks that are too long
- ___ Internally distracted—thoughts, states, moods, daydreams (please specify):

- ___ Externally distracted—sights, sounds, technology such as phone, computer, TV, video games (please specify):

- ___ Rushing through work—sloppy/mistakes
- ___ Not knowing limits (e.g., how long I can sustain attention) or when the best study time is
- ___ Not recognizing when I'm off task

Planning/Prioritization

- ___ Not making a study plan (may not know how)
- ___ Can't break down long-term projects into smaller tasks and timelines
- ___ Having difficulty taking notes or studying for test because I can't distinguish important from nonimportant
- ___ Not using or not knowing how to use agenda/assignment book
- ___ Spending too much time on less important elements—can't put the most important parts or most important assignments first
- ___ Planning unrealistically (e.g., fail to take into account obstacles to the plan)

Flexibility

- ___ Struggling with assignments that require creativity or are open-ended
- ___ Getting stuck on one solution or one way of looking at a problem
- ___ Having trouble coming up with topics or ideas of things to write about
- ___ Having difficulty coming up with "Plan B" if the first attempt didn't work

Organization

- ___ Not using an organizational system or knowing how to design one
- ___ Not being able to find things in notebooks or backpacks
- ___ Losing assignments or important papers
- ___ Not having a neat study area
- ___ Losing electronic data—forgetting where work is stored or what name it's filed under

(continued)

Executive Skills Problem Checklist, Middle/High School Version (page 3 of 4)

Time Management

Can't estimate how long a task will take, due to:

- ☐ overestimating how long it will take to do a task (therefore never getting started)
- ☐ underestimating how long it will take to do a task (therefore running out of time)
- ☐ Chronically late (for school, tutoring, other appointments, and obligations)
- ☐ Difficulty juggling multiple assignments and responsibilities because I can't judge time involved
- ☐ Overcommitted—juggling too many obligations (and I think I can pull it off!)
- ☐ Lacking a sense of time urgency (doesn't appreciate that deadlines are important)
- ☐ Relying on deadline as activator or motivator

Goal-Directed Persistence

- ☐ Not having a long-term goal
- ☐ Having a long-term goal but lacking a realistic plan to achieve the goal
- ☐ Not seeing how daily actions impact goal attainment
- ☐ Not seeing studying as important and making minimal effort as a result
- ☐ Giving up in the face of an obstacle
- ☐ Having a "good-enough" mentality that gets in the way of producing quality work
- ☐ "Not on the radar"—seeing work as not relevant or not important enough to do

Metacognition

- ☐ Can't accurately evaluate skills (e.g., expect to do well on tests in spite of poor past performance; expect to go to a college or get a job without requisite skills or academic record)
- ☐ Can't identify appropriate study strategies
- ☐ Can't plan or organize a writing assignment
- ☐ Can memorize facts but missing the larger context (I do better on multiple-choice tests than essay questions)
- ☐ Having a hard time understanding more abstract concepts (math as well as content-area subjects)
- ☐ Having difficulty making inferences, drawing conclusions, grasping the main idea, reading between the lines
- ☐ Failing to check work/proofread

Other

(continued)

WHAT ARE MY TARGETS?

Executive skill	Specific problem

What are some ways that I could use my executive skill strengths to help me be successful?

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and extend across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Executive Skills Problem Checklist, Elementary Version—Parents

Directions:

1. Read each item and decide whether your child exhibits this problem *to a significant degree* such that it interferes with daily life at home. Keep in mind that some of the items may not be age appropriate for your child.
2. Look over all the items you checked and choose THREE that you think cause the greatest problems. Place a star (★) next to those.

Response Inhibition

- ___ Interrupts when others are talking
- ___ Blurts out inappropriate comments
- ___ Can't wait turn in games or conversations
- ___ Doesn't use acceptable language to handle conflict situations
- ___ Doesn't consider consequences before acting
- ___ Rushes through homework or chores without regard to quality of work

Working Memory

- ___ Can't remember short instructions even right after they're given
- ___ Does not bring all necessary materials to and from school every day (e.g., homework, notebooks/binders, permission slips, gym clothes, lunch money, coats/hats/mittens)
- ___ Has trouble keeping track of schedule when it changes from day to day
- ___ Doesn't remember things necessary for activities outside the home (e.g., sports equipment)
- ___ Doesn't remember to do chores, even when they follow a consistent schedule

Emotional Control

- ___ Becomes easily upset over small things that would not bother others
- ___ Engages in verbal or physical aggression when angry
- ___ Fails to use coping strategies to recover when he/she begins to get upset (or angry, frustrated, anxious)
- ___ Overreacts when provoked by things people say or do to him/her
- ___ Gets "revved up" in some situations (e.g., social gatherings) and has trouble calming down
- ___ Has trouble dealing with disappointment, such as losing at a game or not getting what he/she wants

(continued)

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Executive Skills Problem Checklist, Elementary Version—Parents (page 2 of 3)

Flexibility

- ☐ Doesn't use coping strategies to recover when he/she begins to get upset (or angry, frustrated, anxious)
- ☐ Difficulty managing transitions between activities or settings
- ☐ Can't do open-ended homework assignments (e.g., using each spelling word in a sentence or doing a creative writing assignment)
- ☐ Unable to come up with one or more alternative plans or solutions when the first strategy doesn't work (no Plan B)
- ☐ Gets stuck or fixated on certain thoughts or ideas

Sustained Attention

- ☐ Doesn't complete homework or chores within the time allotted or within suggested time frames
- ☐ Up and down during homework—difficulty sticking with it long enough to get it done
- ☐ Doesn't listen when parents or other adults are talking to him/her
- ☐ Shifts quickly from one play activity to another
- ☐ Doesn't stay focused when engaged in organized activities (e.g., sports)

Task Initiation

- ☐ Doesn't perform daily routines at scheduled times unless prompted
- ☐ Leaves homework or chores until the last minute unless prompted by an adult
- ☐ Finds other things to do rather than chores, homework, daily routines
- ☐ Stretches out breaks and fails to return to work promptly with longer work tasks
- ☐ Dawdles when asked to do a chore, perform a boring daily routine, or switch from a preferred to a nonpreferred activity.

Planning/Prioritization

- ☐ Has difficulty setting priorities (in what order to do tasks, how much time to spend on any given task)
- ☐ Can't make a plan to accomplish a task (even when it's something the child wants to do)
- ☐ Gets sidetracked when following a plan and doesn't get back to it
- ☐ Doesn't know what to focus on when studying for tests
- ☐ Can't break down a task into individual steps (what to do first, second, etc.)

Organization

- ☐ Doesn't hang up coats/put belongings away in designated place
- ☐ Doesn't place materials in a specified place in notebooks, backpacks, desks, and study areas
- ☐ Doesn't follow an organizational system with consistency (e.g., throwing out unnecessary papers, placing homework assignments in assigned spot, organizing school papers)
- ☐ Doesn't have a tidy study area to work in
- ☐ Bedroom and play spaces are a mess, and this doesn't bother him/her

(continued)

Executive Skills Problem Checklist, Elementary Version—Parents (page 3 of 3)

Time Management

- ___ Does not arrive places on time (e.g., coming home from friend's house at agreed-upon time)
- ___ Can't complete daily routines within time limits
- ___ Does not complete assignments by the due date
- ___ Can't adjust work speed to fit the time available
- ___ Can't juggle multiple time demands (e.g., starting homework early on days when child has evening Scout meetings)

Goal-Directed Persistence

- ___ Does not persist with effortful tasks
- ___ Gives up in the face of an obstacle
- ___ Starts projects but doesn't finish them (including preferred activities)
- ___ Wants to quit rather than do the work to get better at something
- ___ Has a "good-enough" mentality that gets in the way of producing quality work
- ___ Can't save up money to make a desired purchase

Metacognition

- ___ Can't judge the quality of his/her own work
- ___ Does not know how to improve work
- ___ Can't solve everyday problems
- ___ Has difficulty making inferences, drawing conclusions, grasping the main idea, reading between the lines
- ___ Can't read or misinterprets the emotions or reactions of others
- ___ Fails to check work/proofread